Roshni Nayar
University of Toronto - Senior Thesis

Bathing Suit Befitting an Indian Lady: Embodied and Racialized Indian Womanhood in the 1952 'Miss India' Beauty Pageant

April 3rd, 1952. Twelve sari-clad women propped on the backseats of flower-adorned cars roll into Brabourne Stadium to a crowd awaiting their entrance. Some women are bashful, shielding their blushing faces from the incoming gaze of the spectators, while some hold their heads and stare back. Some join their palms, greeting the crowd with respectfully joined palms and a muted smile, while others grin at the excitement of the ceremony. These twelve women, hailing from the Indian cities of Delhi, Bombay, Calcutta, Lucknow, Bangalore and Madras coalesced in the nation's largest city and commercial epicenter, Bombay, to participate in an event the first of its kind in the newly emerged independent nation. The 'Miss India' pageant, advertised to young urban women across the nation, emerged out of a particular developmentalist and "feminist" vision of new nation, and sought to define the epitome of Indian womanhood. However, for the new Republic that had so carefully curated its national identity in the decades prior, this would be no easy feat. That "India" was constructed on an entangled system of nationalistic "truths" – including ideas of Aryan-ness and spiritual superiority – meant that all national symbols were recruited to reflect such myths. Within this post-Independence environment in which questions of nation and national identity were heightened, 'Miss India' spoke to questions of "Indian-ness" through women's bodies. The "Indian woman's body", also born in the image of the nationalist ethos, was imbued with deep-seated meanings that dictated acceptable and appropriate behavior. Therefore, in attempting to define the categories of racialized, embodied, and gendered "Indian womanhood", 'Miss India' instead emerges as a site in which these notions were destabilized and reconfigured. Contest winner Indrani Rehman, the professed epitome of Indian womanhood, was thus in a position where she could rework, resist,

and reinforce such notions within the bounds of the pageant platform. This study will outline the Indian "truths" that underlined 'Miss India' and present the ways Rehman disrupted them. In doing so, it seeks to engage with scholarship around gender, sexualities, Indian nationalism to argue that the categories promoted within the pageant and in wider Indian society were inherently incoherent and open to interpretation.

Some trace the roots of the modern beauty contest to the showmanship of P.T. Barnum, who conceptualized and organized photographic beauty contest that were soon adopted by the working classes. However, it was in the early 20th-century that the American middle-classes began to harness beauty pageants in their bid to consolidate authority over the developing commercial culture. Thus, in the 1920s and 1930s, beauty pageants grew to be a respectable form of middle-class American cultural production and was soon replicated in Europe. By way of the post-Second-World-War growing American cultural hegemony, beauty pageants were elevated to global affairs and tools used by post-colonial states to demonstrate their position within the "family of nations."[1] By the 1960s, beauty pageants were elevated to symbols of the second-wave liberal feminism in the United States as feminists denounced such affairs as objectifying and alienating women.[2] With the emergence of new feminist scholarship – such as the work of Judith Butler who famously claimed that "[b]ecause there is neither an 'essence' that gender expresses or externalizes nor an objective ideal to which gender aspires, and because gender is not a fact, the various acts of gender create the idea of gender, and without these acts,

[1] Sarah Banet-Weiser, *The Most Beautiful Girl in the World: Beauty Pageants and National Identity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999), 181.
[2] Banet-Weiser, 34-37.

there would be no gender at all"[3] – scholars began to approach beauty pageants as one arena on which gender was performed and therefore created. By the 1990s, the late-20th-century's globally accelerating commodity culture presented a novel context in which new questions around identity and belonging were posed. In this new context, the beauty pageant was understood as a site in which "meanings ascribed to individual and cultural identities are continually negotiated and often vehemently contested." Sarah Banet-Weiser, in her work on the 'Miss America' beauty pageant, notes that beauty pageants represented a "civic ritual", "a highly visible performance of gender", and a "profoundly political arena." She thus analyzes the national, cultural, racial, and gendered articulation that takes place on the beauty contest platform. Noting that beauty pageants are premised on feminine "typicality and respectability," Banet-Weiser pays particular attention to the subjectivities of participants and does important work to frame beauty contests as a critical site from which to uncover unspoken notions held by participants, pageant organizers, and the public.[4] Taking Banet-Weiser's lead, scholars in the last two decades have heavily utilized this framework to consider beauty pageants as performance of racial, gendered, and nationalistic ideals in various contexts. This study, on the 1952 'Miss India' beauty pageant, is situated within the post 1990s historiography to explore the ways categories of "Indian woman," "Indian body" and the "Indian race" were performed and constituted within the Indian post-Independence nationalistic context.

The 1952 'Miss India' pageant emerged out of a particular vision of the new independent India. Organizational efforts were chaired by Lady Dhanvanthi Rama Rau – an aristocratic,

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[3] Judith Butler, "Performative Acts and Gender Constitution: An Essay in Phenomenology and Feminist Theory," *Theatre Journal* 40, no. 4 (1988): 522.
[4] Banet-Weiser, *The Most Beautiful Girl in the World,* 2.

Western-educated woman's advocate who had dedicated herself to issues of women's empowerment and family planning since the mid-1940s. Rau and her peers at the All India Women's Conference (AIWC) and Family Planning Association of India (FPAI) imagined family planning and limited reproduction as the cornerstone of improving women's lives in the newly independent Indian nation. Connecting family planning to the new nation's broader developmental goals, Rau and her contemporaries imagined limited reproduction as key in removing women from the confines of their homes and into the outside world where they could assume a position in building the nation as equal partners with men. Within Rau's circles, there was little interest in undermining structural inequalities based on class, caste, and gender. Instead, family planning, including education programs and contraceptive use, was positioned as a catch-all for all Indian women's issues in the late 1940s and early 1950s.[5] Rau and her contemporaries imagined family planning as a means to liberate the Indian body from the confines of domesticity and childrearing prescribed by patriarchal Indian families.[6] However, in effect, the family planning efforts sought rework the state as the primary purveyors of Indian sexuality and reproduction in their efforts to harness the labor of all Indians in developing the new nation.[7] Thus, the 'Miss India' pageant was situated within this "feminist" context that imagined Indian women as key actors in building the modern Indian state.

Modelled after the modern American beauty pageant, the Indian event organizers were engaged in a mid-20th-century global phenomenon that saw the birth and rise of such contests all over the world. In 1952, from Peru to Italy and from Japan to Turkey, national beauty contests were held globally to gather competitors for the first 'Miss Universe' pageant to be held in Long

[5] Mytheli Sreenivas, "Feminism, Family Planning and National Planning," *South Asia* 44, no. 2 (2021): 315, https://doi.org/10.1080/00856401.2021.1886731.
[6] Sreenivas, 316.
[7] Sreenivas, 318.

Beach, California, where the winner was promised fame, celebrity, and a seven-year contract with Universal Studios, Hollywood. In March 1952, Indian women were encouraged to sign up for the regional beauty contests held in the major provincial capitals of New Delhi, Bombay, Calcutta, Madras, Bangalore and Lucknow (called 'Miss Delhi', 'Miss Bombay', etc.). From each regional contest, two winners were selected and would go on to compete in the national 'Miss India' contest in April. It was in this 'Miss India' contest that one woman would be selected to represent Indian beauty in the international 'Miss Universe' pageant.[8] For Lady Rama Rau and others, the national beauty contest was an opportunity for Indians to select their "cultural ambassador."[9] According to Rau, the 'Miss India' pageant would "afford an opportunity to [Indian] girls to prove their worth not only in this country but abroad."[10] Therefore, the pageant organizers imagined the beauty contest as a novel platform from which Indian women could demonstrate their capacities in imagining the new India through the labor of representing the nation. Furthermore, the organizers imagined the public displays of Indian women's bodies and "Indian womanhood" as legitimate forms of labor needed for India's development into successful modern nationhood. Rama Rau also imagined both the 'Miss India' pageant and the 'Miss Universe' pageants as stages where Indian women could prove that they "were the equal of women in other nations."[11] At this point in the mid-20th-century, "whiteness" strongly informed hegemonic beauty standards, and beauty contests such as 'Miss Universe' or 'Miss World' celebrated this "universal whiteness."[12] Furthermore, women and women's status were utilized by Indian and foreign thinkers, commentators, politicians, journalists, and more, as

[8] "Classified Ad 13 -- No Title," *The Times of India*, March 6, 1952,
[9] N.T. Babre, "New Horizons: To the Editor, Times of India," *The Times of India*, April 7, 1952.
[10] "'Miss Universe 1953': Indian Beauty to Contest Title," *The Times of India*, February 1, 1952, ProQuest Historical Newspapers.
[11] "'Miss Universe 1953': Indian Beauty to Contest Title."
[12] Banet-Weiser, *The Most Beautiful Girl in the World, 9*.

popular "barometers" from which to judge civilizations. In other words, a nation's claims "modernity" and "civilization" were dependent on the ways they treated their women.[13] Thus, to proponents of the beauty contest, the 'Miss India' pageant and the winner's participation at 'Miss Universe' were "opportunities" for the Indian state and its women to demonstrate their success as a modern nation while defying claims of Indian racial inferiority.

However, in offering to promote the role of Indian women as international "cultural ambassadors", the pageant organizers were also outlining which women could speak for the nation and which could not. For starters, the beauty pageant was an entirely urban affair, and therefore limited to women residing in the major urban centers of India. Furthermore, the pageant was premised on publicly presenting and judging Indian women through this novel and alien platform. Considering mainstream notions of Indian women's rightful place within the home and the adverse inequality and poverty in the newly independent India, most women lacked the financial and familial support to participate in the contest. Therefore, most of the participants were women who existed outside of these norms and restrictions. These included Miss Calcutta Indrani Rehman, a classical Indian dancer who had grown up travelling with her mother's dance troupe in India and abroad, and Miss Madras Tanguturi Suryakumari, an upper-caste Telugu dancer, singer, actor, and freedom fighter, and others currently lost in the archives.[14] Therefore, the pageant organizers attempted to create a platform limited to a certain class of women – those willing and able to handle the pressures of publicity while behaving in line with the pageant organizers' goals. Finally, for the pageant to succeed in these goals – that of presenting Indian women, and by extension, the nation, in a positive light – both the 'Miss India'

[13] Jill Steans, *Gender and International Relations*, 3rd ed. (Cambridge: Polity Press, 2013), 62.
[14] See "Beauty Contest Leads to Riot in New Delhi," *The Hartford Courant*, March 28, 1952. 18-year-old Pamela Hohili, Jodhpur has been identified as Miss Delhi. Little else is known about Hohili.

pageant and Miss India herself needed the public's approval. For Miss India to be accepted as a cultural ambassador and to avoid international humiliation, pageant organizers needed the Indian public's (or at least the upper-class, upper-caste Hindu powerful minority's) full support. Thus, it was imperative for the pageant to maintain an "air of dignity" to be understood as a wholly respectable affair.[15]

In this immediate post-independence India, questions of Indian representation took on a heightened emphasis. Firstly, it is important to note that "India" as a modern independent nation-state was not an inevitable and natural outcome arising out of historical forces. Instead, it emerged out of the careful consideration and construction by anti-colonial thinkers of the 19th- to mid-20th-centuries who imagined and led the efforts to materialize the Indian nation. Within the nationalist efforts of this era, all symbols, such as the "Indian family," "Indian body," and "Indian woman", began to take on new meanings imbued with the nationalist ethos and widely disseminated to the public.[16] With the onset of independent statehood on August 15, 1947, much of these meanings did not shift. Instead, the emphases shifted from curating and legitimizing these symbols, to consolidating and publicly projecting them. Imagining 'Miss India' as a symbol for this carefully curated Indian identity thus places the pageant in an important perspective. Pageant officials, organizers, and participants were in a position where they had to accurately "capture" and "reflect" notions of Indian-ness on a novel platform and through women's bodies. The 1952 'Miss India' pageant therefore emerges as a rich site from which to read the spoken and breach the unspoken notions around embodied, racialized, and gendered

[15] See Bill Becker, "Girls of 30 Nations Will Vie For Title Of 'Miss Universe,'" *Tampa Bay Times*, June 22, 1952.
[16] Anupama Roy, "Gender and Citizenship in India," in *Routledge Handbook of Gender in South Asia* (Abingdon, Oxfordshire: Routledge, 2014), 82.

Indian-ness through the beauty contest's engagement the "Indian race," the "Indian woman" and the "Indian body."

"Race" in South Asia is centered on the Aryan Invasion Theory, first conceptualized by European Orientalist scholars in the mid-19th-century. "Racial science", drawing efforts from scholars the various fields of linguistics, ethnography, archaeology, and more, burgeoned in the 18th-century for Europeans to locate their alleged innate superiority and their colonized populations' innate inferiority in the face of the steadily shifting world order. As British colonial administers, linguists, anthropologists and more, descended into the Indian subcontinent throughout the 17th- to 19th-centuries to "know" and ultimately capitalize on the region, they sought to assess the population and locate them within the developing racial hierarchy that positioned whiteness at its apex. Interpreting material from the written tradition as presented by Brahmins, understood by Europeans as a class of "priests" as spiritual leaders who guarded the Hindu religion, European scholars such as Friedrich Max Muller (1823-1900) posited that a noble race of Central Asians called *Aryans*, from the Old Iranian *arya* of the Zoroastrian *Avesta* and the Sanskrit*arya*, branched off towards the West in the direction of Europe, and towards the South through the regions of today's Iran, Afghanistan and into South Asia between 3000 and 2000 BCE. While the European Aryans were "active and combative", already having developed the idea of "nation", the Southern Aryans were more interested in religion and philosophy than political organization.[17] The *Rig Veda*, an already archaic transcription made between 1500 and 1000 BCE of an oral tradition that was several centuries old, was critical source material for Muller and his peers. Interpreting this subjective text, Muller concluded that it was these

[17] Romila Thapar, "The Theory of Aryan Race and India: History and Politics," *Social Scienti* 24, no. 1 (1996): 5.

fair-skinned noble Southern Aryans that conquered the dark-skinned indigenous *dasas* as they invaded the region between 2000 and 1400 BCE, spreading with them the "Hindu" belief system. He further contended that the Rig Veda's conflict between *arya-varna* and *dasa-varna* was racial, but also based on language and religious practice. With the Aryans' eventual victory came a shift in the landscape – the development of powerful ancient empires and the beginning of a glorious ancient Indian age, according to Muller. Furthermore, the "caste system", a complex set of practices within the region denoting a hierarchal system based on blood and occupation that had captured European attention, was a result of this racialized conflict. Brahmins, the highest *varna* (or caste) were direct descendants of Aryans, while lower castes and untouchables were descendants of the Dasas.[18]

Such European ideas were made manifest within South Asia as British colonists utilized these theories to make the vast and diverse region knowable. Firstly, the "caste system" was formally codified and the Brahmanical tradition was privileged as the true Indian tradition.[19] Furthermore, these theories enabled the creation of racialized contours within South Asian geography, where peoples and cultures in the Northern regions of the subcontinent – the Aryans' first point-of-contact with indigenous population – were privileged as bearing closest resemblance to ancient Aryans. While they heavily used these discoveries in their colonizing project, British colonists remained understandably defensive at mainland European scholars' valorization of the glorious ancient Hindu past, and instead emphasized the "degraded" nature of the Indian tradition, primarily owing to the "despotic" and foreign Muslim Mughal rule of the

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[18] Edwin F. Bryant and Laurie L. Patton, *The Indo-Aryan Controversy: Evidence and Inference in Indian History* (Abingdon, Oxfordshire: Routledge, 2005), https://books.scholarsportal.info/uri/ebooks/ ebooks2/ taylorandfrancis/2013-03-13/1/9780203641880, 44.

[19] Hugo Gorringe, "Victimisation, Violence and Valour: The Context of Dalit Activism in Tamil Nadu," in *Untouchable Citizens: Dalit Movements and Democratization in Tamil Nadu* (New Delhi: Sage Publications, 2005), 136; Dilip K. Chakrabarti, "Colonial Indology and Identity," *Antiquity* 74 (2000): 670..

15th- to 19th-century.[20] Many Indians, however, conducted a wholesale acceptance of these theories, and claimed Brahman-ness and Aryan-ness as a means for social and economic mobility.[21] As the anti-colonial nationalist movement began to take shape in the form of organized movements in the second half of the 19th-century, much of anti-colonialists' efforts "reflected nationalist aspirations to modernity, which would qualify them to 'sameness' with the colonizers, and, at the same time, reflected their 'difference' or distinctiveness."[22] In other words, anti-colonial nationalist thinkers employed much of the language of colonizers to imagine themselves as an independent political entity with equal standing to the British. Nationalist thinkers borrowed heavily from Orientalists as they began to write their own histories, choosing to highlight the nation's glorious Aryan roots and Brahmanical tradition and reframing India as the "cradle of Aryan civilization."[23] Furthermore, using the language of "degradation", Indian nationalist thinkers further insisted that the pure Hindu tradition first established by the Aryans had indeed been steadily degraded over centuries by both foreign Muslims and British rule.[24] Within this configuration, the "Aryan-ness" inherent in some Indians, namely upper-caste and upper-class Hindus, was positioned as equal to the "whiteness" inherent in Europeans. "Aryan-ness" was understood as the "Indian" manifestation of "whiteness", in that there was racial 'sameness' but cultural 'difference'. Thus, "Aryan-ness" came to represent the best elements of Indian-ness.

By the time of Indian independence in 1947, these ideas of race and caste were imprinted onto the fabric of the Indian nation. Most political actors, thinkers, and decision-makers hailed

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[20] Bryant and Patton, *The Indo-Aryan Controversy, 42*.
[21] Dilip K. Chakrabarti, "Colonial Indology and Identity," 670.
[22] Anupama Roy, "Gender and Citizenship in India," in *Routledge Handbook of Gender in South Asia* (Abingdon, Oxfordshire: Routledge, 2014), 84.
[23] Bryant and Patton, *The Indo-Aryan Controversy, 18*.
[24] Chakrabarti, "Colonial Indology and Identity," 667

from upper-class and upper-caste families that had managed to secure social and economic benefits through the colonial caste hierarchy, and they understood holding on to these ideas as a means to maintain their power.[25] As the Indian nation approached independent statehood, she was positioned as the continuation of the pure and ancient Hindu tradition, reformed to remove the degrading vestiges of colonial and Muslim rule, and grounded within racialized ideas of "Indian-ness." However, these claims of racialized Indian-ness and its immense emphasis on Aryan identity did not challenge broader colonial racial hierarchies that placed whiteness as the apex. Instead, it relegated "Indian-ness" at the top of the hierarchy beside whiteness, and therefore left claims of European racial superiority unmatched.

Despite these favorable outlooks on whiteness, the broader meanings attached to *embodied* whiteness in India were far from positive. In her study of colonial Southeast Asia, Ann Stoler explores the colonizer's deep-seated fear of "degeneration" – the loss of manhood, civilization, whiteness… -- that governed colonial relations between themselves and the foreign land around them.[26] Within the Indian subcontinent, medical texts and travel journals written by English clergymen, physicians, betrayed this fear in nearly explicit terms. Englishmen bemoaned the tropical climate and its detrimental effects on the English body – William Tenant, an English clergyman in Calcutta in 1796 claimed that the Bengal climate presented 'a severe trial to every European constitution," giving European men a "sallow and livid complexion."[27] A. R. Martin, a medical topographer wrote in 1837 that although Indians were clearly of Caucasian origin, their

[25] Gorringe, "Victimisation, Violence and Valour: The Context of Dalit Activism in Tamil Nadu," 118.
[26] Ann Laura Stoler, "Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power: Gender, Race, and Morality in Colonial Asia," in *Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power: Race and the Intimate in Colonial Rule* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2010), 21.
[27] David Arnold, "Race, Place and Bodily Difference in Early Ninteenth-Century India," *Historical Research* 77, no. 196 (2004): 256.

"constitutions" had been so long affected by climate, religion and custom, that they differed considerably, physically and morally, from Europeans.[28] Finally, William Twining, a doctor at Calcutta's General Hospital noted that Europeans should avoid rice, the diet of the "effeminate" Bengalis, and instead recommended the wheat diet of the reputedly 'martial' (read: Aryan) races of the North.[29] In these ways, through discussions of medicine, food and climate, the English were speaking to ideas of race and racial degeneration. The European's fear that his body too would degrade as the Southern Aryan's had points to his conviction that the European body was fundamentally different to the Indian body. The difference was the matter of innate superiority, and the English had to ensure that their inner essence and source of their superiority remained untainted.[30] Out of this attitude emerged the drive to classify, categorize, and hierarchize the Indian population in relation to the white European.[31] Through this racial delineation, argues Stoler, the colonizer sought to promote the coherence of such categories.[32] In other words, they imagined these categories as "obvious", in that there were visible and easily recognizable differences between the European and Indian body, and sought to promote this "obviousness" in their program of exploitation and subjugation of the local population.

Just as Indians in the 19th-century heavily borrowed the European language of "Aryans" to gain social benefits, so too did anti-colonial thinkers employ these notions of race and difference as an integral element of their liberation movement. Anti-colonial thinkers maintained that there indeed lay a fundamental difference between Indian and non-Indian bodies, but this difference was a matter of *Indian* superiority, and not European. In his analysis of the Indian

[28] Arnold, 259.
[29] Arnold.
[30] Stoler, "Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power."
[31] Chakrabarti, "Colonial Indology and Identity," 669.
[32] Ann Laura Stoler, "Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power," 25.

anti-colonial movement, Partha Chatterjee notes the creation of two distinct "domains" – the "outer" domain, and the "inner". The outer domain was "public" and material, and included matters of the economy, statecraft, science, and technology; it was in this domain that the "West" had demonstrated its superiority by successfully colonizing India. Within the "inner" domain, however, lay the "domestic", the cultural practices, and religious beliefs– it was this spiritual segment that held the "pure Indian essence" that foreign colonizers had never managed to conquer. Furthermore, it was this "inner" domain that Indians needed to protect and could use to claim superiority over the West.[33] Joseph Alter, in his study of popular men's health literature in the late-colonial period, critiques Chatterjee's "separate domains" by bringing up the question of bodies. Bodies, as housing this pure, spiritual, Indian essence inherent in Indians, but also as material objects acted upon by outside forces, lay within the intersection of the inner and outer domains.[34] In this context, bodies took on a emphasized meanings during the Indian anti-colonial movement and were recruited to reflect the truth of the "pure Indian essence". Alter examines the meanings given to celibacy, sex, and sexuality in the early to mid-20th century and contends that sex and sexuality were understood as "polluting" to the Indian essence. As a result, Indians were encouraged to embark on a project of self-sacrifice through the abstinence of sex to bolster the nation's morality in its fight for independence.[35] While both men and women were encouraged to engage in this sexual abstinence, there was also clear gendered asymmetry.

Within Chatterjee's configuration, the "outer" domain was coded as masculine, and the "inner" as feminine. To anti-colonial thinkers, it was seemingly "natural" to code the inner

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[33] Partha Chatterjee, "Colonialism, Nationalism, and Colonialized Women: The Contest in India," *American Ethnologist* 16, no. 4 (1989): 624.
[34] Joseph S. Alter, "Celibacy, Sexuality, and the Transformation of Gender into Nationalism in North India," *The Journal of Asian Studies* 53, no. 1 (1994): 47.
[35] Alter.

domain as feminine and embodied by women. As biological reproducers, and hence, reproducers of the innate superior Indian-ness, women's bodies had to be especially protected in the fight for liberation. This was heightened by popular notions that the sexual exploitation of Indian women by English colonists was a critical factor in the "degradation" of Indian-ness that nationalists sought to reclaim.[36] Furthermore, one important way British colonists justified their intrusion into the cultural, social, and religious practices of the subcontinent was by emphasizing its harmful effects on Indian women. The colonizers lamented the treatment of Indian women at the hands of Indian men, labelling gender relations of the subcontinent as barbaric and oppressive in relation to the fair and rational treatment of European women.[37] To Indian nationalists, these gender relations were understood as originating from the authentic Indian culture. As such, gender relations belonged to the inner domain and needed to be protected from foreign influences. Indian anti-colonists thus reversed the colonizer's claims and instead positioned Indian gender relations as *superior* to Europeans', based on the notion that Indian women were well protected by their husbands, communities and nation as bearers of the authentic Indian-ness. In this arrangement, women's celibacy and sexual abstinence was mounted as a matter of national honor, for if foreign influences were to breach the sacred boundaries of Indian women's sexuality and Indian essence would once again be threatened. The "Indian woman" was hence birthed in the image of a chaste (and asexual), submissive, and "domestic" female who guarded her – and by extension, the nation's – pure Indian essence (and sexuality) while aiding her husband in his "public" fight for liberation.[38] The "Indian woman", including her body and the

[36] Roy, "Gender and Citizenship in India."
[37] See Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" in *Colonial Discourse and Post-Colonial Theory: A Reader* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1994). In this influential essay, Spivak coins the phrase "white men saving brown women from brown men" to describe British reformers efforts of eradicating the practice of sati (widow burning) in 19th-century India.
[38] Roy, "Gender and Citizenship in India."

subject it housed, were constructed as stable categories in opposition to the "bad" Indian woman – she who remained in the "public", typically, but not exclusively, lower-class women who could not afford to remain in the "domestic" sphere, leaving herself vulnerable to attack and the further degradation of the nation's essence. Therefore, the "Indian body" and the "Indian woman" were born as fundamentally different to the non-Indian body and non-Indian woman, as they housed the nation's essence. "Indian-ness" was thus a gendered construct built on the bodies of Indian men and women who were tasked with materializing their Indian essence.

As Stoler notes, although these categories may have been presented as cohesive, stable, and fixed, the realities betrayed such notions. Within her study of colonial Southeast Asia, she looks specifically at the ways mixed-race bodies, with both "Indochinese" and Dutch "blood", challenged the "cohesiveness" of racial categories established by the Europeans.[39] In the same vein, mixed-race bodies of English and Indian blood threatened the "cohesiveness" of categories such as "Indian body" and "Indian woman." Anglo-Indians, a community of those with mixed Indian and English ancestry had been a recognized fixture of the region's landscape since the 18th-century. Choosing to identify with their British (and usually paternal) side and isolating themselves from "mainstream" Indian culture, Anglo-Indians typically sought to replicate the English upper-middle- and middle-class standards of domesticity and morality.[40] Anglo-Indian women, marked by their "Western" dress, language, social traditions, were visibly different to Indian women. Fewer restrictions were imposed on Anglo-Indian women, who were free to take employment outside of the home, socialize freely with men, and marry whom they choose. In the late colonial period, Anglo-Indian women worked as receptionists, nurses, stenographers, shop

[39] Stoler, "Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power."
[40] Alison Blunt, *Domicile and Diaspora: Anglo-Indian Women and the Spatial Politics of Home* (Malden, Massachussetts: Blackwell Publishers, 2005), 60.

assistants, and English-medium teachers.[41] Furthermore, as nascent film and theatre industries began developing in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, many 'white' actresses in India, including Anglo-Indian, Eurasian, and Jewish women found employment as actresses, singers, and dancers. Anglo-Indian women dominated the Indian silver-screen between the 1920s and 1940s, where they would perform in front of large crowds and engage in provocative film scenes as erotic, exotic and daring "vamps".[42] This enabled Indians to formulate strong connections between Anglo-Indian women and "public-ness". In this juncture of inter-racial sex and their perceived "public" status, Anglo-Indian women were seen as highly "licentious" and were believed to easily threaten Indian men's sexual abstinence.[43] Furthermore, within the context of the nationalist movement, all "Western" influences were seen as potentially threatening and dangerous.[44] Anglo-Indian women, located outside the category of "Indian woman", were thus constructed as erotic and exotic and imagined as a threat to Indian celibacy. Thus, the Anglo-Indian woman and her dangerous sexuality had to be separated from the general population lest she endanger the social order.[45] Anglo-Indian bodies were constructed as firmly un-Indian – they lacked the "Indian essence" that deserved nation respect and protection. Thus, the sharp distinction made between the Indian and non-Indian body was spoken to through Anglo-Indian bodies – despite their Indian heritage, Anglo-Indian bodies, in the minds of some nationalists, represented a "degraded" Indian-ness, thus denying them room in the emerging independent India.

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[41] Sarah Rahman Niazi, "White Skin/Brown Masks: The Cast of 'White' Actresses From Silent to Early Sound Period in Bombay," *Culture Unbound* 1-, no. 3 (2018): 336.
[42] Rahman Niazi, 342.
[43] Rahman Niazi, 336.
[44] Roy, "Gender and Citizenship in India," 61.
[45] Rachel Tu, "Dressing the Nation: Indian Cinema Costume and the Making of a National Fashion, 1947-1957.," in *The Fabric of Cultures: Fashion, Identity, and Globalization* (New York: Routledge, 2008), 35.

These notions of degradation and difference were widespread in the years leading up to and following independence in 1947. *Taxi Driver*, a popular Hindi-language film released in 1954, explores these questions of race, gender, and Indian-ness. The film follows Mangal, a taxi driver in Bombay, in a love-triangle with Sylvie, an Anglo-Indian dancer, and Mala, a village girl who recently migrated to the metropole. Sylvie and Mala are presented as opposites – while Sylvie is loud, boisterous, comfortable drinking and smoking in a bar with male patrons, Mala is shy, quiet, preferring to remain at home and recite the *Mahabharata*. The dichotomy between the "vamp" with her sexual promiscuity and the heroine's adherence to traditional gender codes was largely typical of Indian films of this period. However, Sylvie's (attempted) performance of "Indian womanhood" reveal deeper notions around embodied Indian-ness. In the film, Sylvie soon realizes that Mangal is falling in love with Mala. In an attempt to win Mangal over, Sylvie replaces her typical wear, composed of a tight skirt and a Western blouse, with a sari draped in the Nivi style.[46]

This sari style was first promoted by Jnanadanandni Devi Tagore, social influencer of the mid 19th-century and sister-in-law of Bengali literary figure Rabindranath Tagore. Tagore adapted the Hindu purity laws that dictated that clothing be uncut and unstitched with Victorian ideals of public modesty by wearing her sari over a "blouse" and "petticoat" – now staples in Indian women's wardrobes. For mobility, she then draped the *pallu*, or decorative end of the sari, over her left shoulder, leaving her right hand free to carry out tasks.[47] Understanding the potential of this new drape in the anti-colonial movement, she promoted the style and offered instructions for re-creation in popular women's periodicals. However, it was only in the 20th century that the Nivi sari took on significant political meaning. According to Rajeswari Rajan, "the development

[46] Chetan Anand, *Taxi Driver* (Navketan Films, 1954).
[47] Tu, "Dressing the Nation: Indian Cinema Costume and the Making of a National Fashion, 1947-1957," 30.

of an 'Indian-ness' free of chauvinistic regional markers among its citizenry is, of course, one of the nationalist aspirations of the Indian state." The Nivi sari was perfectly aligned with these conditions, and within this nationalist context, it emerged as a sartorial marker of Indian-ness and femininity that was at once "modern" and "traditional."[48]

Therefore, when Sylvie dons the Nivi sari and begins to serenade Mangal, she attempts to perform ideal "Indian womanhood." However, her movements are awkward, and her innate eroticism reveals itself despite the modesty provided by the sari.[49] She fails to present herself as an "Indian woman" in the way Mala can, and thus loses out on the protection, respect, and legitimacy that Mangal can provide. The messages of *Taxi Driver* are clear – Sylvie's failure to present herself as an "Indian woman" suggest notions that "Indian womanhood" is not a "performance" Rather, "Indian-ness" is imagined as a real essence that is reflected in the actions and behaviors of "real" Indian women and cannot be established by only the manipulation of exterior appearances. While Mala's covered body and docile nature reflect her status as a "real" Indian woman who possesses the authentic Indian essence, Sylvie's failure to materialize in these ways is understood as a reflection of her "degraded" Indian-ness, borne out of both her mixed-race ancestry and her position as a "public" body. Thus, the film *Taxi Driver*, positions a sharp contrast between the "Indian" and "non-Indian" body, wherein "Indian body" is apparently distinct from the non-Indian and clearly reflects the Indian essence that lay within it. The Indian essence was not something that was "acquired" but was naturally occurring in some women but not others. The possession of this Indianness housed within the "Indian body" was an innately superior quality and deserving of cherishment, protection, and love, while the same could not be said for the non-Indian.

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[48] Tu, 34.
[49] Anand, *Taxi Driver*.

Thus, when "Orthodox Hindus" protested the 1952 'Miss Delhi' contest, burning effigies of the (yet unselected) Miss Delhi and Miss India outside of the contestants' hotel and picketing outside the stadium walls on the day of the national pageant, they were articulating notions of Indian-ness, Indian womanhood, and appropriate behavior of Indian bodies. Protestors claimed that "this type of selection of half-naked girls" was "highly immoral, uncultural, and against India's ethical values,"[50] thereby tying the Indian nation's values, morals, and culture to women's bodies. Their contention that the contest was against Indian morality presents a view that the beauty contest was a "degenerative" force that threatened the national cohesion. The specific reference to "half-naked girls" also further articulates the notions of difference between Indian and non-Indian women and their bodies. By claiming that a revealing a woman's bare skin was against Indian morals, they positioned a view in which the "appropriate" Indian body was that which was "covered." As Michel Foucault argues, for the modern state that sought to govern life itself, "sex was a means of access both to the life of the body and the life of the species."[51] The "Indian body", as noted, was understood as a "reflection" of the Indian essence, a real thing that could be "corrupted" by sex and sexuality. Therefore, in this context, sexuality was intimately connected to both the material body and the Indian inner essence. In the new Indian state, women were required to be vigilant and to continue practices of celibacy and asexuality to maintain the newly independent Indian state. The condition of being publicly "half-naked" was understood as entirely un-Indian, and by extension, foreign. Thus, it could not be applied to Indian bodies. The pure inner Indian-ness that existed in real "Indian bodies" had to be carefully shielded from

[50] "Miss India Burned in Effigy: Grudyism in New Delhi," *The Manchester Guardian*, March 28, 1952.
[51] Michel Foucault, "Right of Death and Power over Life," in *The History of Sexuality, Vol. 1* (New York, N.Y: Pantheon Books, 1986).

"foreign" influences. Thus, the body (a "reflection") had to be similarly protected. To protestors, an Indian woman revealing her skin, the body's largest sexual organ,[52] was understood as a dangerous, threatening, and potentially transgressive act that went against the Indian values so carefully cultivated in the decades preceding Independence. Furthermore, the Indian body was differentiated from the non-Indian body – the non-Indian body, in the form of an Anglo-Indian woman, for example, could not "bring out" an authentic and undegraded Indian essence by manipulating her external appearance; the Indian essence that rested within the Indian body, however, could certainly be influenced by external manipulation. Therefore, in their resistance to the 'Miss India' beauty contest, protestors presented a vision of the "Indian body" as a permeable and sanctified object that needed to be outwardly marked as such through modest clothing that shielded both the material body and inner essence from corrupting "foreign-ness".

Other critics also presented similar notions of corporeal permeability and Indian women's outward appearances. One writer in the *Times of India* condemned these contests as "frivolities" that made "the vain vainer and flighty flightier." Furthermore, the writer notes that the beauty contests only "advertise the city belle" and "take no account of the rustic flowers born to blush unseen and waste their fragrance on the desert air."[53] Here, the writer deplores the emphasis and pride that beauty queens placed on their outward experiences and valorizes the rural woman in her "unseen" beauty, ultimately calling for the de-emphasis of Indian women's outward appearances. In the context of Indian women's outward appearances reflecting but also shaping her inner essence, the explicit attention given to "beauty" was understood as inappropriate, as it diverted attention from the inner qualities and instead promoted the manipulation of exterior appearances that could make negative impressions on the essence.

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[52] Nina G. Jablonski, *Skin: A Natural History* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2006), 119.
[53] "Glamour Girls," *The Times of India*, April 8, 1952.

Pageant organizers, in their bid to present the pageant as a respectable and legitimate event to select India's "cultural ambassador", offered concessions to the Indian public. Firstly, instead of basing the contest entirely on the women's outward appearances, pageant organizers allotted forty-five percent of the points to the women's "cultural achievements" and the remaining fifty-five percent to their beauty, charm, and character.[54] Furthermore, while across the globe women presented themselves in one-piece swimsuits as a segment of their 1952 national beauty contests, the Indian pageant decided to omit this tradition. Instead, Indian competitors were only required to wear "national dress". As they sauntered down the makeshift platform erected in Brabourne stadium on April 3, 1952, the women all wore saris draped in the Nivi style (See Figure 1 in the Appendix). In offering and enacting these concessions, pageant organizers were engaged with questions of embodied and racialized Indian womanhood alongside the protestors and critics. Furthermore, that the pageant went on despite protestors decrying it the contest as foreign and immoral suggests varied outlooks on "respectable" Indian womanhood. While protestors positioned the beauty pageant and its premise of presenting Indian women's bodies in a public manner as entirely dishonorable to the women involved and the nation, pageant organizers instead imagined the pageant as a highly respectable platform from which Indian women could address questions of nation and Indian-ness. In enacting the public's will to de-emphasize outward appearances, and demonstrating their commitment to "respectability", organizers shifted the balance of the contest to highlight Indian women's inner Indian essence while maintaining the objective of the contest as a *beauty*. Furthermore, the forty-five percent granted to "cultural achievements" gave the Indian public a voice from which to comment on the

[54] Babre, "New Horizons: To the Editor, Times of India."

contestants, as it was not simply their subjective beauty on trial, but their inner Indian essence that all Indians had a stake in. Therefore, the pageant organizers' division of points worked to counter claims that the competition promoted "flightiness" by holding the women accountable to the public. Furthermore, that the pageant required the women to wear saris demonstrates special treatment and a consideration of the implications of an Indian woman's bare skin on a public platform. This worked to further the notion that Indian bodies were fundamentally, visibly, and coherently different to non-Indian bodies. Thus, the pageant constructed the ideal Indian woman through engagement with "modern" notions of rightful women's place of building the nation alongside men while confirming that Indian women's bodies and sexualities were under the purview of the entire state and community.

On April 3rd, Indrani Rehman, dancer and child of an Indian diplomat father and American dancer mother, was crowned Miss India. Her mother, Ragini Devi (born Esther Luella Sherman) was a professional Indian classical dancer in the United States in the early 20th century. In the 1920s, she married Indian diplomat Ramalal Balram Bajpai and converted to Hinduism. In 1930, the couple separated, and Devi began a new life in India with her daughter Indrani. Devi first became interested in Indian dance in the early 20th century, at the exact moments that the form was being eradicated within the Indian subcontinent and proliferating in North America and Europe. The anti-nautch movement (*nautch* or *naatch*, meaning dance) beginning in 1892 and persisting into the early 1910s was spearheaded by British social reformers and the Indian comprador classes as they rallied for the eradication of the "temple dancing" and *devadasi* traditions. Historically, *devadasis* (or temple dancers) belonged to a hereditary lineage of dancers who dedicated their lives to perfecting their craft under the tutelage of spiritual teachers and

musicians, sometimes referred to as *gurus*, who belonged to a hereditary class of their own. This dance community was an integral element of social and spiritual life, as they often performed at royal courts and temples from which they received patronage. Within the practice, it was not uncommon for families to give away their young daughters to temples where they would grow to be *devadasis* to relieve some financial burden. Furtheremore, this dance community thrived outside the domestic economy of upper-caste Hindu women and were seen to reflect a "deviant lifestyle".[55] To the British, who relied on upper-caste knowledge to make the region knowable, *devadasis* and temple dancing were almost entirely unintelligible. Upper-caste disdain of temple dancing, along with the common and intimate relationships between female dancers and patrons, musicians, and teachers, enabled the British to interpret *devadasis* as prostitutes sanctioned by Hindu religious practice and despotic rulers. Thus, in the late 19th-century, along with a host of other reform efforts around abolishing sati (or widow burning), female infanticide, and child marriage, the anti-nautch movement's efforts to eradicate temple-dancing were justified by the need to protect Indian women and realign Indian gender relations and supported by upper-caste "reformist" Hindus who understood temple dancing as a manifestation of a degraded Hindu tradition. After banning the practice, many members of the dance community lost their livelihoods. Some turned to a life of poverty, while others turned to prostitution; some married, while few managed to join dance troupes where they would continue performing to international audiences across Europe and North America.[56] It was these dancers that so deeply influenced Devi/Sherman to dedicate her own life to the craft.

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[55] Pallabi Chakravorty, "Hegemony, Dance and Nation: The Construction of the Classical Dance in India," *South Asia: Journal of South Asian Studies* 21, no. 2 (1998): 110-12.

[56] Priya Srinivasan, *Sweating Saris: Indian Dance as Transnational Labor* (Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 2012), 22.

As the drive to restore the "pure" Indian essence from its degraded form accelerated in the 1930s, Indian dance was granted new meanings in the shifting political order. Rukmini Devi Arundale, an upper-caste and upper-class theosophist and dancer, was an integral actor in creating these new meanings. Inspired by European schools of dance, such as ballet, Arundale pioneered the efforts to "restore" Indian dances in the 1930s.[57] Ragini Devi entered the Indian classical dance scene in the early days of these pioneering efforts and established herself as a pioneer of Indian classical dance in her own right. Devi became the first woman and foreigner to learn the Keralite dance-style of Kathakali and went on to popularize the form in India and abroad with her dance troupe.[58] The efforts to legitimize Indian dance were based on the need to "Sanskritize" and "cleanse" the craft of its "impure" elements. Thus, they aimed to align this burgeoning "Indian classical dance" within Hindu scripture and the "Hindu patriarchy". Dance reformers, such as Devi and Arundale, organized institutions to teach dance to young middle-class women under the tutelage of male *gurus*. The *gurukul* tradition was promoted, in which men from traditional dance families were recognized as the true bearers of this authentic Indian tradition. The upper-class and middle-class women who sought to enter this arena had to bow down to this modern patriarchal structure as a necessary step to be recognized as legitimate classical dancers.[59]

Within this dance theology, the male gurus were understood as the "true" creators of this spiritual, "traditional" art form that had been steadily degraded by foreign invaders. They were given full credit for bringing the art to life through their dancers' bodies. Little credit was given

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[57] Royona Mitra, "Living a Body Myth, Performing a Body Reality: Reclaiming the Corporeality and Sexuality of the Indian Female Dancer," *Feminist Review* 84 (2006): 75.
[58] Sitara Thobani, *Indian Classical Dance and the Making of Postcolonial National Identities: Dancing on Empire's Stage* (Florence: Taylor and Francis, 2017), 34.
[59] Chakravorty, "Hegemony, Dance and Nation: The Construction of the Classical Dance in India," 117

to the dancers themselves. Instead, the dancer's body was understood as an "incorporeal", "illusory vehicle," and all the dancer was required to do was "empty her own subjectivity" to make space for characters of Indian mythology to fill her up instead. The dancer's body housed the subject only temporarily and was later shed as she transformed herself for the craft.[60] In a certain sense, the dancer embarked on a project of "self-sacrifice" where her body was "volunteered" to the dance institution and audiences for the sake of this divine craft. This construction of the Indian classical dancer's body contrasted with that of the non-dancer. In the case of the non-dancer, the body was strongly de-emphasized for the inner essence to make itself visible in its purest form, unmedicated by external manipulation. For the dancer however, the subjectivity or personhood was deemed irrelevant, and all emphasis was placed on the body – not as a material object, but as a vessel for her *guru*'s spiritual teachings to come alive. Thus, a separation was made between the dancer's body and her inner subjectivity that allowed her to publicly present her body without placing her inner essence in a vulnerable position. Therefore, Indian dancers' bodies were used to domesticate the potentially transgressive sexual and embodied elements of society, cultivating instead the respectable forms of upper-middle class entertainment and symbols of Indian culture.

Furthermore, to firmly establish Indian classical dance as respectable entertainment, it had to be performed in front of respectable people, and so the dance was transported from temple to theatre.[61] This "ancient Indian tradition", as it was referred to following the 1930s, shifted from representing the "deviant" underbelly of the degraded Hindu faith to the property of the privileged Hindu middle-class. In this way, the "new" dance community, now made up of upper- and upper-middle-class reformists constructed Indian classical dance as a "post-colonial modern

[60] Srinivasan, *Sweating Saris: Indian Dance as Transnational Labor, 28*.
[61] Srinivasan, 109.

form […] masquerading as a traditional form" by linking this craft to an "essentialized iconic spirituality."[62] By the 1950s, then, Indian classical dance had largely entered the pantheon of "respectable" national art forms, marked by the establishment of national dance "Akademies."[63] However, segments of the population continued to associate the modern female Indian classical dancers with overt sexuality in the same realm as actors and doubted if they could appropriately actualize Indian womanhood considering their status in the "public". Therefore, Indian dance existed as both a potentially dangerous and inappropriate activity because of its references to female sexuality while also being hailed as an important "recovered" tradition. Dancers, particularly female dancers, were thus required to navigate these notions around their bodies as they conducted their craft.

When Indrani Rehman, a bi-racial Indian dancer, was crowned 'Miss India' and sent to Long Beach, California to represent her nation in the international beauty contest, she would do so while navigating this complex terrain of racialized and embodied Indian femininity. As she stepped into her sash, Rehman was transformed into a symbol of Indian-ness, the embodiment of Indian values, and a cultural ambassador. In certain ways, Rehman was tasked with making the private and sanctified Indian essence publicly and internationally known through her equally sanctified body. However, to maintain legitimacy and public approval, Rehman had to, at once, "expose" her Indian-ness to the foreign while protecting and maintaining this Indian-ness as sanctified. In this space and within these bounds, Rehman defined her own notions of the "Indian."

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[62] Srinivasan, *Sweating Saris: Indian Dance as Transnational Labor,* 110.
[63] Chakravorty, "Hegemony, Dance and Nation: The Construction of the Classical Dance in India," 117.

For her cultural achievements, Rehman was likely credited for her years dedicated to Indian classical dance. In elevating Rehman for her cultural achievements, pageant organizers elevated Indian classical dance as a respectable craft for young Indian women. This wholesale acceptance for the form represents a dramatic shift from the early 20th-century attitudes towards Indian dance and highlights the immense success of reformers such as Arundale and Devi in positioning the form as emblematic of "Indian femininity". For her own part, Rehman successfully transported Indian classical dance into a novel arena; distanced from theatres and troupes, and outside the gaze of the *gurukul* system, she intwined her craft with her own name and body. Indian classical dance's premise – that of corporeal separation from the host's subjectivity for the sake of the craft and the dancer's legitimacy – was disrupted when Rehman presented her dancer-self as an inseparable element of her "Indian woman"-self. She posited her body as not just an "illusory vehicle", but as a tangible and corporeal form intimately linked with her subjectivity as an "Indian woman," therefore disturbing certain attitudes towards dance, corporeality, and appropriate behavior for Indian bodies.

While Rehman was praised for her cultural accomplishments in Indian classical dance, she was also hailed as the ideal Indian beauty. Although her mother Ragini Devi's heritage and racial background was no secret, the Indian media maintained a silence on Rehman's mixed racial background. Several factors could account for this silence. For pageant officials, who were responsible for maintaining the pageant's reputation as a respectable affair, mentioning Rehman's mixed ancestry may have contributed to claims of illegitimacy, particularly since the event had already angered an aggressive minority. Considering the notions of "Western" influences as dangerous and popular attitudes towards Anglo-Indians, organizers may have chosen to omit such details to avoid potential outcries. American news outlets were keen to present Rehman as a

mixed-race woman while Indian newspapers did no such thing. However, by denying Rehman's "whiteness" and claiming her as an "Indian beauty", the media, pageant officials, and Rehman herself were effectively appropriating Rehman's "whiteness" as "Indian-ness". Claiming Rehman as of "mixed"-racial background would have implicitly forged a gap between the "Indian" and the "white" race. Thus, by leaving Rehman's racial heritage unspoken and leaving it an open secret, the media and the pageant implicitly established "Indian-ness" and "whiteness" in terms of sameness. In these ways they spoke both to national claims of "Aryan-ness" and pageant officials' claims of racial sameness. Thus, the 'Miss India' pageant functioned as a platform from which "Indian-ness" could stake its claim on "whiteness" and emphasize their shared Aryan background. Rehman was also personally engaging with these unspoken questions of Indian-ness and race. Despite having a shared racial heritage with Anglo-Indians, Rehman was not understood and did not understand herself as possessing a "degraded" Indian essence. On the contrary, Rehman was hailed for her inner essence, reflected through her dedication to Indian culture and as marked by the forty-five percent. In doing this, Rehman positioned that the pure Indian essence was not degraded by the intrusion of "biological" whiteness, but rather, cultural factors that isolated Indians from their cultural roots. In doing so, Rehman defied claims that "whiteness" inherently degraded the Indian essence and, thus, aligned implicitly herself with notions of Aryan same-ness.

Rehman also spoke to notions of Indian-ness on her own terms by defining for herself the meanings given to Indian women's bodies. Although the Indian pageant organizers omitted the swimsuit competition, the Indian participants and public understood that the selected Miss India would need to don a swimsuit when she arrived at Long Beach to compete in 'Miss Universe'. Furthermore, pageant organizers did not consider the prospect of an Indian woman in a bathing

suit as improper, and instead insisted that "no girl will be asked to do anything unbecoming of an Indian lady."[64] Thus, by acquiescing that it was inappropriate for women to be "half-naked" in front of Indian audiences and insisting that it was entirely appropriate in the context of 'Miss Universe,' pageant organizers displaced the notion of an "Indian woman's body" as a stable and fixed category, and instead positioned that 'Miss India's' body shifted meanings as she moved from 'Miss India' to 'Miss Universe.' Thus, when Indrani arrived at Long Beach to compete in the 'Miss Universe' pageant, she did so while navigating the varying notions of "Indian women" and their bodies as she moved through different these different contexts.

American newspapers widely reported on the national beauty contests before 'Miss Universe' and were particularly captivated by the Indian case as they discussed Rehman's mixed-ancestry and the violent protests against the pageant. However, American media was most intrigued by the Indian lack of a swimsuit contest. Reporting on Rehman as 'Miss Universe' contestants made their way from New York to California, newspapers wrote that Miss India "has agreed to put on a bathing suit for the first time – in a matter befitting an Indian lady, of course."[65] Here, a bathing suit is described as something Rehman would not typically wear, but that she is willing to for the purposes of the 'Miss Universe' pageant. Rehman donning a bathing suit is positioned as a self-sacrifice of sorts as she contends that the 'Miss Universe' pageant and its purposes are larger than her own personal preferences. By placing her preferences behind her duties as Miss India, she aligns herself with the Indian pageant's visionaries who sought to harness all Indian women's labor at the small cost of transgressing some patriarchal norms that stood between themselves and the larger goal of Indian national development. Moreover, in claiming that she would wear a swimsuit "in a matter befitting an Indian lady," Rehman spoke

[64] Becker, "Girls of 30 Nations Will Vie For Title Of 'Miss Universe.'"
[65] Becker.

further on the meanings given to her body. Firstly, in doing so, she makes claims that swimsuits are "un-Indian" and that they do not suit Indian women the way they may suit other, non-Indian, women. She thus sympathized with mainstream Indian society's prescriptions of modesty and aligned with nationalist claims of Indian difference. However, she also challenged these notions by maintaining that public exhibition of bare skin need not necessarily be incompatible with respectable Indian womanhood. As such, Rehman tasked herself with demonstrating that bathing suits could be worn in ways that sufficiently preserve the "Indian-ness" innate in the "Indian woman."

The swimsuit competition was and remains a traditional element of any modern American beauty pageant, with many pageant organizers globally replicating this in their 1952 national contests. As Banet-Weiser notes, the swimsuit segment seeks to assess the women's adherence to standards of ideal physical "fitness" to hopefully reveal more about the women's "inner" fitness. Thus, the swimsuit competition is for the body to "be read as a transparent statement of the interior moral qualities of each contestant."[66] On first glance, this may seem highly reminiscent of Indian notions of corporeal permeability. However, there exists a significant gap between these outlooks. While both the "Indian" and "Western" understandings of bodies contend that the subject's corporeal form is a "reflection" of their inner qualities, this "Western" or American view emphasizes that these "interior moral qualities" can be shaped towards the ideal through manipulation of the body. The "Indian essence", however, exists *a priori*; it is innate and exists in its purest form with limited external manipulation. In other words, while external manipulation in the American mind was a means to improving the internal, external manipulation within the "Indian" understanding could result in *degradation* of the

[66] Banet-Weiser, *The Most Beautiful Girl in the World*.

internal. Rehman in her role as Miss India at 'Miss Universe' had to thus confront these various notions around the body.

In the 'Miss Universe' swimsuit competition at the end of June 1952, all thirty "international" women were given standardized Catalina swimsuits and instructed to wear plain light, dark, or nude heeled shoes. Within these bounds, the contestants were free to accessorize themselves – most chose simple earrings, necklaces, and makeup. In her study of the Miss America contests, Banet-Weiser notes that the swimsuit competition is "almost totally devoid of subjectivity" and designed to "homogenize" the women participating by reducing them to their corporeal forms.[67] However, Rehman had committed herself to resisting this kind of homogenization by her insistence on Indian difference. Thus, despite the homogenizing effects of the standardized clothing, Rehman sought to mark herself as different to the other twenty-nine competitors.

At the swimsuit competition, the women were ridden down the main city streets of Long Beach in individual floats towards an outdoor platform where they were instructed to sit, stand, be gazed at by onlookers, and pose for photographs. With their swimsuits, Miss Chile wore small, studded earrings and a simple necklace, Miss Hong Kong wore a necklace with a cross, Miss Denmark wore a pearl choker, and Miss Turkey wore a pair of dangled earrings, to describe a few. Miss India, however, wore a *bindi*, a flower garland in her hair, dangled earrings, and a small stack of bangles on each wrist. Standing aside the other women, Rehman markedly stood out with her surplus of accessories (See Figure 2).

While these accessories may seem like innocuous markers of typical Indian beauty standards, they carry with them deep-seated spiritual meanings that were invoked by Rehman for

[67] Banet-Weiser.

her goals. The *bindi*, from the Sanskrit word *bindu* meaning "drop" or "spot", is "traditionally" worn as a red circle in between the eyebrows or on the forehead by Hindu women. Positioned atop the mystic third eye to attract certain energies, and sometimes understood as a tool to balance one's internal constitution the *bindi* is imbued with an array of meanings. Although limited to signifying marital status in certain contexts, the *bindi* exists as a typical accessory worn by Hindu Indian women, today and in the mid-20th-century.[68] Furthermore, bangles, too, are far from frivolous displays of Indian femininity. Bangle production is referenced in Indian epics, such as the *Māhabhārata* and *Rāmāyana*, and enjoys a long history within the region. "Hindu" meanings sometimes associate bangles with marital status and sanctity, as bangles are given as gifts to brides-to-be and offered to Hindu deities such as the goddess Parvati.[69] Finally, flowers and flower garlands are equally significant in ritual Hindu practice. Flowers, including flower garlands, are often offered to *murtis* (images, statues, or images of deities) as a part of Hindu religious practice and worn by women in their hair for special occasions and the everyday.[70] Thus, while the *bindi*, *gajra*, and bangles were largely innocuous symbols of Indian femininity, they were also used to mark certain objects – such as *murtis* and Indian women's bodies – as sanctified sites deserving of respect. Thus, in modifying the standard swimsuit competition wear to "befit" an "Indian lady" by incorporating these accessories, Rehman was marking her body as a sanctified "Indian body", and therefore, different to other bodies present.

To protestors, respect towards the Indian woman's body was demonstrated by covering its surface and concealing the innate female sexuality, understood as a direct inroad to the inner

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[68] Mary Grace Anthony, "On the Spot: Seeking Acceptance and Expressing Resistance through the Bindi," *Journal of International and Intercultural Communication* 3, no. 4 (2010): 347.
[69] Alok Kumar Kanungo, "Glass Bangles in India: Antiquity, Functional Use and Traditional Production," *South Asian Studies*, 2021, 3.
[70] Gavin Dennis Flood, "Hindu Monotheism," *Cambridge University Press*, Elements in Religion and Monotheism, 2020.

Indian essence. Furthermore, the "exposition" of Indian women's skin was understood as placing the inner essence in a vulnerable position and valid grounds for public denunciation. To Rehman, however, revealing this "sexuality" was an innate element of the 'Miss Universe' swimsuit competition and a part of her duties as Miss India. Thus, Rehman maintained that the exposition of skin was not grounds for denunciation by continuing to mark her body as a sanctified "Indian" site. In doing so, Rehman positioned that an "Indian woman's" loss of honor was not strictly dependent on her corporeal condition, but on the subject's failure to recognize and respect her body as an "Indian body."

Within these bounds and in the narrow space between competing ideas around the "Indian race", the "Indian body" and the "Indian woman", the 'Miss India' and 'Miss Universe' pageants provided a platform from which Rehman could define her own notions of embodied, racialized, and gendered Indian-ness. Through her words, actions, and silences, Rehman transports her body through various contexts and presents novel ways of experiencing "Indian-ness" in which the viability of an Indian woman's body was not hedged on the denial of sexuality for the maintenance of its sanctified status but was instead hedged on the overt and outer markers of the body as a sacred space. Finally, Rehman balanced both American and Indian approaches to the body by using her accessories to reference her "inner essence" for the Americans and while marking her body as a "different", sanctified, and protected space for the Indians.

Five years after India was granted independent statehood, questions of the "Indian race" remained unanswered. Furthermore, competing claims over women's bodies as tools for the "modernization" of the nation and as "reflections" of the "authentic Indian essence" remained

unmediated. In attempting to survey some of the many meanings around "Indian-ness", what has ultimately emerged out of this study is a (hopefully) detangled arrangement of competing and complementary systems of thought that converged around the 1952 'Miss India' beauty pageant. In selecting Miss India, the pageant attempted to address these unanswered questions. Having to select the epitome of ideal Indian womanhood from a class of women that transgressed some norms around Indian women and the "domestic", unspoken notions around the "Indian body", "Indian race" and "Indian woman" were brought to the surface. As Miss India, Indrani Rehman's body was recruited by these discursive systems to reflect Indian "truths" of cultural "difference" and racial "sameness" with Europeans. Furthermore, Rehman had to contend with notions of corporeal permeability and inner sanctity. At once, she was required to "reveal" her Indian-ness through her body, while protecting this "Indian-ness" by respecting her body as a sacred space. However, while Rehman was expected to define and close such signs that were inherently open and undefinable, she instead defined such notions on her own terms, and positioned novel ideas of "Indian-ness" based on her own subjectivity. In wearing a swimsuit in Long Beach, Rehman demonstrated her commitment to the developmentalist cause and situated her body as a tool within this context. However, she also visibly marked herself as possessing the pure interior Indian essence that maintained its venerated status when her sacred sexuality was made public. As a person of mixed-racial heritage, Rehman also destabilized notions of racialized Indian-ness as degraded by the "biological" mixing of "whiteness." Thus, she was able to successfully position new definitions of racialized and embodied Indian womanhood.

Appendix

Figure 1: 'Miss India' winner Indrani Rehman, third from the left ,and 'Miss India' first runner up Tangaturi Suryakumari, sixth from the left, posing with seven other competitors at Brabourne Stadium before the contest. *Miss India 1952 Participants*. April, 1952. Photo Division, Ministry of Information & Broadcasting, Government of India.
https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Miss_India_1952_participants.jpg

Figure 2: Miss India Indrani Rehman standing with other 'Miss Universe' contestants at the swimsuit competition. *Indrani Rahman at the Miss Universe contest at Long Beach, California in 1952*. June, 1952. The Rahman Family Collection. https://www.rediff.com/news/special/when-my-mum-danced-for-chou-enlai-and-the-dalai-lama/20190725.html

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